Facial Recognition Surveillance

Framework Regulation over Categorical Prohibition

Piter Garcia

IDAI700: Ethics of Artificial Intelligence
Rochester Institute of Technology
pzg8794@rit.edu

October 5, 2025

1 Part 1: Understanding the Arguments via the Authors (Hartzog, Selinger, Rhee) Lens

1.1 What makes AI surveillance different from traditional surveillance?

Stanley identifies the difference as a *"phase transition"* from passive recording to active real-time monitoring. Traditional cameras required expensive human review; AI surveillance is cheap, scalable, and tireless.

1.2 How do the authors define *"obscurity"*?

The authors define obscurity as the practical difficulty of finding information due to transaction costs. Unlike secrecy, obscure information exists publicly but remains unlikely to be discovered.

1.2.1 Why do they consider it essential to our individual and collective lives?

Obscurity enables democracy *(protecting political organizing)*, individual development *(allowing experimentation without permanent consequences)*, and collective well-being.

1.3 How do the authors define *"normalization"*?

The authors define it as an *unexceptional habituation*, where a technology becomes an unremarkable background, and *favorably disposed normalization*, where people view practices as acceptable by observing others' participation.

1.3.1 How do they see normalization eroding privacy protections?

They argue that it creates a *"privacy death spiral"*, in which each acceptance lowers resistance to the next intrusion. Furthermore, they contend that our laws facilitate this via harm thresholds, ignoring "privacy nicks", consent frameworks, and expectations.

1.4 Why do they single out facial recognition as uniquely dangerous among biometric technologies?

The authors single out facial recognition as uniquely dangerous among biometric technologies because it combines four distinctive threats that can create an unprecedented surveillance capacity:

1. **Legacy databases**—billions of exploitable photos
2. **Harder to hide**—cultural/legal face-covering restrictions
3. **Core to identity**—faces central to human recognition
4. **Acts as beacon**—faces are assessed everywhere at a distance, unlike fingerprints or DNA

2 Part 2: Critical Assessment

Facial recognition should *not* be banned. While the authors correctly identify serious surveillance risks, I find their solution fundamentally flawed.

2.1 Strengths and Weaknesses

2.1.1 Strongest Aspect

The strongest aspect is the obscurity framework—distinguishing secrecy from a practical difficulty of discovery captures genuine civil liberties concerns that warrant protection.

2.1.2 Weakest Aspects

The ban proposal suffers from problems Luke Munn diagnosed in abstract AI ethics principles: it's **meaningless** (vague scope), **isolated** (technically naive), and **toothless** (unenforceable). *"Ban facial recognition"* lacks specificity: ban *where, what, how?* Without precision, companies engineer workarounds—gait recognition, social graph analysis, behavioral signatures—achieving identical surveillance outcomes.

The authors commit a category error, treating technology as having **intrinsic behavior** when AI systems have ***framework-determined* behavior**. Every deployment involves framework decisions: data sources, validation

criteria, retention policies, and governance structures. Harm comes from **deployment frameworks** *(mass surveillance, indefinite retention, no oversight)*, not algorithms themselves. Bans create asymmetric disadvantage: democratic governments lose capability, authoritarian states ignore it, and criminals exploit it.

2.2 Alternative Approaches

Could regulations adequately address the concerns raised without resorting to a ban?
Yes—framework regulations can comprehensively address all surveillance concerns the authors raise without prohibiting the technology entirely.

2.2.1 Framework Regulation Components

Effective regulations should target deployment contexts, not algorithms:

1. **Location restrictions**, prohibit mass surveillance at protests and allow warranted missing person searches
2. **Data governance**, auto-deletion after 30 days, ban cross-database matching, prohibit biometric data sales
3. **Technical standards**, accuracy audits across demographics, differential privacy, transparency requirements
4. **Organizational safeguards**, community oversight, impact assessments, criminal penalties for misuse

2.2.2 Embedding Obscurity Protections

Crucially, Hartzog's obscurity functions embed directly into these frameworks: geographic exclusions protect political organizing, retention limits preserve developmental freedom, and edge processing maintains relational authenticity. This preserves beneficial uses while preventing harms—something prohibition cannot achieve.

2.3 Broader Implications

Accepting the FR technology ban argument, what other AI technologies/uses warrant prohibiting?

Accepting Hartzog's infrastructure normalization logic creates an *untenable slippery slope*:

2.3.1 The Consistency Problem

If infrastructure normalization justifies bans, consistency requires prohibiting internet protocols, smartphones, and social media—all surveillance-enabling infrastructures with beneficial uses. Hartzog never explains why AI-powered facial recognition is categorically different from AI analyzing data from smartphones, social media activity, or internet traffic—each of which is an equally normalized surveillance infrastructure.

2.3.2 A Better Distinction

The appropriate regulatory framework uses harm reversibility: prohibition for irreversible harms, heavy regulation for addressable harms, light regulation for minimal harms.

2.3.3 Toward Collaboration

The authors correctly diagnose risks but alienate necessary collaborators through adversarial framing. Their tone—*"most dangerous surveillance tool ever" and the "indifference" by developers*—ensures experts won't engage. We need to invite collaboration: specific regulations addressing concrete concerns, technically informed implementation guidance, and acknowledgment of beneficial applications. Rather than treating technology as destiny, recognize *frameworks determine whether AI serves or surveils humanity.* That's a governance challenge requiring education, democratic engagement, and technical collaboration—not prohibition.

Word Count: 599 words total (Parts 1 and 2 combined, excluding questions and titles)